

Study Guide for the Oral Midterm Exam
ECON 623, American Economic History, Fall 2026

- **Date and sign-up.** The oral midterm is on Monday 19 October during our class time, 4:30–7:10 PM. On Monday 12 October I will email a link to a Calendly sign-up sheet. Each slot is 15 minutes. Sign up for one slot. If your Disability Services accommodation gives you extra time on exams sign up for two consecutive slots and send me the accommodation form before the exam.
- **Joining.** The Calendly confirmation email gives your slot and the Zoom link. Join at the start of your slot and not before because another student may still be finishing.
- **Equipment.** Take the exam on a laptop or desktop computer with your camera on. Phones are not allowed. You will draw diagrams on the Zoom whiteboard so practice using it before the exam.
- **Notes.** You may have your notes and the readings open. I will ask you to explain each answer so a diagram copied from your notes without an explanation earns little credit.
- **Format and grading.** I will ask three questions. Two are on the guaranteed topics below. I choose the third and it can be on any reading or lecture from Weeks 1–6. I grade each question out of 20 as you answer and tell you your grade at the end of the exam. The midterm is 30 percent of the course grade.
- **Guaranteed topic 1. Cities (Week 6).** Explain the three theories of why cities are where they are (locational fundamentals, increasing returns and random growth) and what each predicts after a shock to a city. Be ready to draw those predictions on the whiteboard. Then explain what Davis and Weinstein (2002) learn from the bombing of Japanese cities, what Bleakley and Lin (2012) learn from the portage sites that railroads made obsolete, and what the two papers establish together that neither establishes alone.
- **Guaranteed topic 2. Allen and Clark (Week 5).** Explain Allen's (2011) account of why the Industrial Revolution began in Britain and Clark's (1987) account of why output per worker in cotton mills differed across countries. Then put the two papers against each other. Clark argues that the wage is a poor measure of what labor costs a firm. Explain what that implies for Allen's argument that wages high relative to the prices of capital and energy made labor-saving machines profitable in Britain.